CENTRAL AMERICA (including the Caribbean)

OSTA RICA (9 September)

Harvesting of 1999/2000 first season cereal and bean crops has begun under normal conditions. The outlook is good for the maize crop, particularly in the main producing regions of Brunca and Huetar Norte. Annual output is forecast to be a near average 27 000 tonnes, assuming favourable conditions continue. Production of paddy in 1999 is anticipated to be an above-average 290 000 tonnes, but not enough to meet domestic demand. Some 90 000 tonnes will need to be imported in 2000 (January/December) marketing year. The output of beans, an important staple, is expected to be a low 19 000 tonnes, compared to 25 000 tonnes in 1998/99.

UBA (9 September)

Normal rains have resumed, following months of prolonged drought, which affected minor foodcrops, fruits and pastures. The rain situation still needs to be closely monitored in producing areas with successive years of low rainfall. The rainy season is until October. The rains benefited recently planted 1999/2000 first season cereal crops. Harvesting has only started and maize output is forecast at an average 81 000 tonnes, compared to 76 000 tonnes last year when crops were affected by the dry spell. Paddy output is also expected to increase from 300 000 tonnes in 1998 to some 380 000 tonnes. Imports of some 375 000 to 400 000 tonnes would however still be required to meet demand.

OMINICAN REPUBLIC (9 September)

f Weather conditions favoured planting of 1999/2000 second season cereal crops which began recently. Prospects are good, particularly for maize, and outputs for the year (both crops) are forecast to increase from last yearï¿½s weather affected crop. An average maize production is expected, but imports of some 650 000 tonnes to 700 000 tonnes would nevertheless be required in the 1999/2000 (July/June) marketing year, mainly to meet an anticipated expansion in demand for animal feed, following a contraction in the poultry sector last year due to hurricane ï¿½Georgesï¿½. 1999 paddy output is also forecast to be slightly above average. Other foodcrops and pastures are reported in good condition.

L SALVADOR (9 September)

Normal to heavy rains throughout the season benefited 1999/2000 first season maize, paddy and bean crops. Harvesting is underway and production of maize is expected to recover substantially from production last year which was affected by hurricane ï¿½Mitchï¿½. Output for the year is provisionally forecast at 682 000 tonnes, compared to 555 000 tonnes the year before. Paddy output is also forecast to increase from 50 000 tonnes to some 60 000 tonnes, while bean production is anticipated at 72 000 tonnes, some 35 percent above last year. The arrival of first maize and beans into markets reduced prices, affected earlier by speculation and stockpiling during the lean period.

Wheat imports in 1999/2000 (July/June) marketing year are expected to be around 175 000 tonnes, similar to 1998/99, while maize imports (August/July), mostly for the feed industry, are forecast to decrease to 150 000 tonnes compared to 264 000 tonnes last year.

UATEMALA (9 September)

Heavy rains and flooding in early July damaged 1999/2000 first season coarse grain and bean crops somewhat. The worst affected areas were Boca Costa del Sur, Esquintla and Quetzaltenango. A detailed assessment of damage to the agricultural sector has not been made yet. Maize output is provisionally forecast at a near average 1 million tonnes. Production of beans is expected to be about average while an above-average paddy output is anticipated.